CLASS 5 HANDOUT

Moderation and Grace, Truth & Time

Finding Peace Within

Complex trauma is about

- Our belief system
  - Our past or history
  - Our present or the filter we view life through
- Extremes
  - Completely happy – Absolutely miserable
  - Thoroughly enmeshed – Totally detached
  - If you do not agree with me unconditionally, then you are against me entirely
- Value
  - Who holds my value?

Source of moderation issues

- Observing and reacting to immoderate caregivers
  - Exhibiting the opposite behavior
  - Do you reflexively react or choose to respond?
- Feeling invisible
  - Childhood needs were ignored
  - Wants were the focus
  - Extreme behaviors received attention
- Repetition Compulsion
  - Desire to fix something or master something from our past
- Value
  - Do we need to check it out?
- Overwhelm = Moderation issues

Moderation is

- Balance
  - Let the pendulum swing from one extreme to the other
  - To find the calm in the middle
  - Do not have to do more today than what is reasonable
- Empathy
  - Having strong internal boundaries
  - Sharing an experience without sharing the feelings
- Acceptance
  - Moments in time do NOT define us (we are NOT our behavior)
  - Making a mistake is only that (mistakes are normal)
  - Avoid the shame bind
  - Welcome vulnerability causes fear to recede

The either/or extremes

Mark where you usually land on each line. Moderation is living in the middle.

Symptom	One extreme		The other extreme
Self-esteem	Less than	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Better than
Boundaries	Too vulnerable	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Invulnerable
Owning reality	Rebellious / bad	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Perfect / good
Needs and wants	Too dependent	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Antidependent or needless / wantless
Operating in extremes	Immature / chaotic	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Overmature / controlling

Moderation and Reality

- Body
  - How a person dresses or sees themselves
- Thinking
  - Black or white; right or wrong; good or bad
- Behavior
  - Extreme behaviors: over the top or absent
- Feelings
  - Adult Feeling: mature, authentic, emotional response to thoughts
    - Indicates our Reality, Boundaries, Self Care are functioning in a healthy manner
  - Adult-Induced Feeling: the result of empathy
    - Indicates our Reality, Boundaries, Self Care are functioning in a healthy manner
  - Frozen Feelings from Childhood: frozen in moment of time
    - Anger, pain, or fear
    - May respond in ways that are not age appropriate
    - May have minimal emotional response to significant event
  - Adult-to-Child Carried Feelings: starts in childhood and carries into adult life
    - Feel overwhelmed and out of control (Shame)

Grace, Truth and Time

Sorting out Good and Bad: Ideal Self versus Real Self

*From **Changes That Heal** by Dr. Henry Cloud*

- Tendency to solve the problem of good and bad by SEPARATING the two
  - Creates inability to tolerate weakness and failure in ourselves or others
  - To navigate life successfully, must be able to live with both
- IDEAL Self is imagined perfection
  - Internalized values from our upbringing coupled with our own wishes for ourselves
- REAL Self is the one we truly are
  - Weak, broken, and not what we imagined
- Relationships between them
  - Problem: Ideal judges the real as BAD so deny part of who we are. Leads to secondary symptoms
  - Intrinsic Solution: Acceptance of the BAD. Do not question if good or bad. Ask “what am I doing?”
- Value the REAL self as perfectly imperfect

Four ways we deal with good and bad

- Deny the bad
  - We see ourselves or others as all good, and put people on pedestals
- Deny the good
  - Buried under the demands of the ideal, we give up standards altogether
- Attack and judge
  - "I'm so stupid, worthless, bad": condemnation that hurts and doesn't heal
- Accept
  - Hold onto the ideal as a goal while accepting and forgiving the real: grace and truth together
- The question is not "Am I good or bad?" but "What am I doing?"

Exercise: My ideal self and my real self

*Adapted from **Changes That Heal** by Dr. Henry Cloud*

	My "ideal" self	My "real" self
Body		
Thoughts		
Feelings		
Behavior		

1. How much of my real self do others know?

2. What messages does my ideal self send my real self?

3. Where do those messages come from?

4. How do I change those messages?

Grace

- Moderation: how much baggage to unpack or fears to conquer or obstacles to hurdle
- The Positive: Undeserved Kindness
  - Bestowing compassion and love towards a person/self and wanting nothing in return
- The Negative: Complacency
  - Deny existence of a problem. Cannot experience intimacy because lack truth for connection
- Without TRUTH free to behave as one wishes regardless if excessive or unacceptable
  - “That’s the best I could do”
  - “I can’t help that he reacted that way”

Truth

- Reality: limits, direction, and guidance make the structure of life
  - Who are we and how does that fit into it
- “Do I need to clean it up?”
  - Coming up short and struggling with success leads to painful feelings
- Without GRACE quick to judge
  - “Should-ing” all over ourselves

Grace and truth need each other

- Grace without truth
  - License: broken relationships, self-will run riot
- Truth without grace
  - Judgment: hiding and denial; fear, guilt, and shame; anger and blaming
- Grace with truth
  - Love with limits: accepted as we are, with structure to grow
- Where was your family on the grace–truth scale? Where are you?

Time

- Needed for the process of change to occur
  - The pendulum swinging from one extreme to another will settle with TIME
  - Messy is okay
  - Doing our best doesn’t look the same every time
- Takes TIME to recognize GRACE and need for it
- Takes TIME for TRUTH to sink in

Forgiveness

*From **Forgiving Our Parents, Forgiving Ourselves** by Drs. David Stoop and James Masteller*

- Two paths after a hurt: an injury or hurt leads to a choice
  - The path of forgiveness: blaming stops → I cancel the debt → freedom and recovery
  - The path of bitterness: blaming continues → I nurse the blaming → bitterness and resentment
- What forgiveness is (and isn't)
  - "Forgiving a person who has hurt me means that I give up the need for revenge or punishment so that I can feel good inside myself. It doesn't mean that I must keep the person in my life... It doesn't mean I approve of the person's actions." (*Facing Codependence*)
  - "If we don't [forgive], we are handcuffing ourselves to the one who hurt us. Forgiveness is the knife that will cut through those handcuffs." (*Changes That Heal*)

The six steps of forgiveness

1. Recognize the injury: What happened? Who did it? What effect did it have on me?
2. Identify the emotions involved: fear, guilt and shame, anger
3. Express the feelings: talk them out with a safe person, or write them out
4. Set boundaries to protect yourself
5. Cancel the debt
6. Consider the possibility of reconciliation

Forgiveness is not reconciliation

- Forgiveness is something I can do on my own
  - It doesn't need the other person to cooperate, or even know
- Reconciliation takes two people
  - Both own their part and work through it; it is not always possible
- Forgiving ourselves
  - The IOUs we hold against ourselves are just as real, and just as damaging

Thoughts to ponder

- People who do not move, do not feel the chains holding them in place
- Do not accommodate, come at it as you are
- Counter steer against what has been handed down
- Change occurs when we brush up against something uncomfortable

Finding Our Truth

*Excerpt from **The Language of Letting Go** by Melody Beattie*

We must each discover our own truth. We must stand in our own light. We often need to struggle, fail, and be confused and frustrated. That's how we break through our struggle; that's how we learn what is true and right for ourselves. There is no easy way to break through and find our truth. But we can and will if we want to. Each of us has our own share of truth, waiting to reveal itself to us. Each of us has our own share of the light, waiting for us to stand in it, to claim it as ours. Each experience, each frustration, each situation, has its own truth waiting to be revealed. Don't give up until you find it—for yourself.

Take-home: The unsent letter

*From **Forgiving Our Parents, Forgiving Ourselves** by Drs. David Stoop and James Masteller*

1. Make a list of the "wrongs done to me." Be accurate and objective. The goal is not to wallow in self-pity but to lay a foundation of understanding.
2. Write a letter to the person who hurt you, stating what happened and how it made you feel. **Never send it.** Its purpose is to help you clarify your feelings.
3. If you'd like, share what you have written with a safe person who will listen without trying to fix it.
4. Cancel the debt: when you are ready, write "canceled" across the letter, or burn or bury your list.

Remember: forgiveness is a process. You can work through the same steps for the IOUs you hold against yourself.

MY UNSENT LETTER (KEEP THIS PAGE; DO NOT SEND IT)

Dear _____,

Group Questions

Check-in first Did you try any of your wants? Did any bring you joy, or surprise you?

Answer from whichever level fits where you are tonight. It's fine to stay in Start.

Start

JUST STARTING OUT

1. When life gets stressful, do you tend to do too much, or shut down?

2. Which do you need most for yourself right now: grace, truth, or time?

Go deeper

APPLY TONIGHT'S IDEAS

3. What did moderation, or the lack of it, look like in the home you grew up in? Where does that show up in you now?

4. Pick one either/or pair from tonight (less than vs. better than, too vulnerable vs. invulnerable…). Which side do you swing to, and what would the middle look like?

Stretch

FOR A BIGGER CHALLENGE

5. What part of your real self have you been hiding behind your ideal self? What might happen if a safe person saw it?

6. Which step of forgiveness is hardest for you right now, and what would help you take it?